Lecture 16: A Person in the World of People: Self and Other, Part I

Introduction to Psychology · Yale University, Spring 2007 · Professor Paul Bloom

Study guide based on the lecture transcript. Source: https://oyc.yale.edu/psychology/psyc-110/lecture-16 (CC BY-NC-SA 3.0).

Before you start

This is the first of two lectures on social psychology: how we think about ourselves, other people and groups. Professor Bloom describes biases that shape how we see ourselves and how we explain other people's behavior.

Learning goals

After this lecture you should be able to:

- Describe Milgram's package study and explain what "connectors" are.
- Explain the spotlight effect, the transparency effect and the Lake Wobegon effect.
- Explain cognitive dissonance, using Festinger's one-dollar study and hazing.
- Describe the fundamental attribution error and how it differs across cultures.
- Give examples of how proximity, similarity and attractiveness affect liking.

Key ideas

1. Social Psychology and Connections between People

- Stanley Milgram gave a package to 160 people randomly chosen in Omaha, Nebraska, and asked them to get it to a stockbroker who worked in Boston. Most succeeded, in at most six steps: the origin of "six degrees of separation". Bloom says this is "not true in general"; it was a single experiment in the United States.
- In about half the cases, the packages went through two people. Malcolm Gladwell (The Tipping Point) calls such people **connectors**: social "hubs", like big airports.
- In class, students circled the people they know (who also know them) in a list of 250 names from a Manhattan phone book. Gladwell finds the average for a college crowd is 21.
- Sociologists say a big benefit of Yale is **acquaintances**, not just powerful friends. Acquaintances matter, for example for getting a job.

2. Aspects of the Self: The Spotlight and Transparency Effects

- **Spotlight effect** (Tom Gilovich): we overestimate how much other people notice us. Students wore a T-shirt with an embarrassing picture. They were wrong "by a factor of about two": they thought, say, 100 people noticed, but 50 did. Others are busy noticing themselves.

- **Transparency effect:** we believe we are more transparent than we are. In a class demo, a student lied about one of three answers, and the class could not agree which one. People are quite good at lying, but they feel that their secrets "bleed out". We also overestimate how much other people know, which can make teaching hard.

3. Aspects of the Self: You're Terrific!

- People see themselves as better than average as students, teachers, lovers and especially drivers. This is the **Lake Wobegon effect**, from Garrison Keillor's story about a place where all the children are above average.
- Possible reasons: we mostly get feedback when we do something good, and we use different criteria (one driver is a great parallel parker, another is very careful). There also seems to be a motivation to feel good about ourselves.
- **Self-serving bias:** students who did well on the midterm say "I'm smart"; those who did poorly say "the midterm was unfair." This has been found in athletes, CEOs and accident reports.

4. Aspects of the Self: Cognitive Dissonance

- **Cognitive Dissonance Theory** (Leon Festinger): an inconsistency in our heads causes an unpleasant state, "dissonance", and we act to reduce it. A simple example is the **confirmation bias**: people read magazines that support what they already believe.
- Louisa Egan's M&M study at Yale: after choosing between two equally liked M&Ms, people then chose a third one over the one they had turned down. Four-year-olds and monkeys show this too.
- **Insufficient justification effect:** Festinger paid people twenty dollars or one dollar for a boring task. The one-dollar group rated the task as much more fun. They could not say "I did it for twenty dollars," so they decided it was interesting.
- In the book When Prophecy Fails, Festinger studied a group who waited on a mountain for the world to end. When it did not end, they said their actions had delayed it.
- More examples: hazing (humiliating or painful treatment of new members) makes people like the group; unpaid volunteers are more committed; children rewarded for drawing later value the activity less.
- Dissonance is not simple inconsistency: "we adjust our beliefs to make ourselves look more moral and rational than we are."

5. Self and the Other

- An **attribution** is a claim about the cause of someone's behavior. Heider's insight: we explain other people's actions by their personality. The **fundamental attribution error** is giving too much weight to the person and not enough to the situation.
- Quiz show study: a coin flip decides who asks the questions, but observers still rate the quiz master as more intelligent.
- People confuse actors with their roles. Robert Young, who played the doctor Marcus Welby, got thousands of letters asking for health advice.
- The error is not universal. In a study comparing the United States and India, children at about age eight do not commit it, but in Western cultures it develops. U.S. newspaper reports on murders

stress the person; reports in India stress the situation more.

- Summary: we enhance the self but oversimplify the other. "I do something stupid, it's an off day."

6. How We Think about Other People

- We like people who are honest, kind, smart and funny, but three more basic processes also affect liking.
- **Proximity** (being physically close): in a Manhattan housing project, 90% said their best friend lived in the same building. The **mere exposure effect**: the more we see something, the more we like it. James Cutting showed paintings before his Intro Psych lectures; later, students liked the paintings they had seen more, even with no memory of them.
- **Similarity:** friends, and husbands and wives, tend to be similar. Similarity predicts the success of a marriage.
- **Attractiveness:** attractive people are thought to be smarter, more competent, more social and nicer. This may create a **Matthew effect** ("the rich get richer"). Teachers rate attractive children as smarter.

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning in simple English	Example from the lecture
connector	a person who knows a great many people; a social "hub"	Gladwell's term
acquaintance	someone you know, but not a close friend	contacts made at Yale
spotlight effect	believing others notice us more than they do	the embarrassing T-shirt study
transparency effect	believing our thoughts are easier to see than they are	the lying demo in class
Lake Wobegon effect	seeing ourselves as better than average	most drivers think they are great drivers
self-serving bias	crediting ourselves for success, blaming the situation for failure	explanations of midterm results
cognitive dissonance	an unpleasant feeling caused by an inconsistency in our heads	the one-dollar boring task
confirmation bias	looking for information that supports what we already believe	reading magazines from your own political side
attribution	a claim about the cause of someone's behavior	"you're a rude person"
fundamental attribution error	explaining behavior too much by personality, too little by situation	the quiz show study
mere exposure effect	liking something more because we have seen it before	James Cutting's paintings

Term	Meaning in simple English	Example from the lecture
Matthew effect	good things lead to more good things	attractive children rated as smarter

Check your understanding

1. What did Milgram's package study find, and why is "six degrees of separation" not true in general?
2. What is the spotlight effect? Describe Gilovich's T-shirt study.
3. Give two possible explanations for the Lake Wobegon effect.
4. In Festinger's study, why did the one-dollar group rate the boring task as more fun?
5. How does hazing show cognitive dissonance at work?
6. What is the fundamental attribution error? How does the quiz show study show it?
7. How do the United States and India differ in this error?
8. A student did well on the midterm and says, "I'm smart." His friend did badly and says, "The test was unfair." The first student thinks his friend is just lazy. Which two biases do you see?

Answer guide

1. Most people got the package to the stockbroker in at most six steps. But it was a single experiment in the United States.
2. We overestimate how much others notice us. Students in embarrassing T-shirts thought about twice as many people noticed as really did.
3. We mostly get feedback when we do well, and we use different criteria for "good".
4. The twenty-dollar group had a justification (the money). The one-dollar group did not, so they decided the task was interesting.
5. After painful hazing, people think, "I went through a lot of stuff to get into this fraternity. It must be really good."
6. Giving too much weight to personality and too little to the situation. Observers rate the quiz master as smarter, although a coin flip gave him that role.
7. In Western cultures the error develops; in India people make more situational explanations.
8. The friend shows the self-serving bias. The first student shows the fundamental attribution error.

English practice

Useful phrases from the lecture

- "It turns out that ..." - introduces a surprising research result.
- "The idea is appealing, that ..." - says an idea is attractive, often before a "but".
- "This is actually a useful thing to know." - shows that a finding has practical value.
- "You might have predicted it the other way around." - shows that a result is unexpected.
- "So, to sum up, ..." - introduces a short summary.

Speaking task (with your AI tutor)

- Explain cognitive dissonance in 4-6 sentences. Use "dissonance", "justification" and "hazing".

Writing task

- Write one paragraph (80-120 words): Choose the spotlight effect, the Lake Wobegon effect or the fundamental attribution error. Explain what it is and describe one study or example from the lecture.

Study with your tutor

Things to say to your tutor in Live conversation:

- "Let's review Lecture 16. Ask me questions about the spotlight and transparency effects, one at a time."
- "Quiz me on the key vocabulary of Lecture 16."

- "I will explain cognitive dissonance in my own words, with Festinger's one-dollar study. Check my understanding and my English."
- "Give me everyday situations and ask me which bias from Lecture 16 each one shows."

Readings from the original course

- Gray, Peter. Psychology (5th edition), chapter 13

My notes